say a thing to each other for a while as the news sank in. Every dream of mine was being fulfilled and I thanked God for all the blessings and kindness. Then we opened a bottle of champagne to celebrate and, to be honest, the champagne just flowed from then on.

We watched television for a while as we tried to come to terms with the enormity of the award. Every channel was showing it as Breaking News. I was the first sportsperson in the history of India to be awarded the Bharat Ratna. It was certainly the biggest honour of my life and coming on the day I had bid my final goodbye to cricket made it all the more special. I had already been appointed to the Rajya Sabha, the upper house of the Indian Parliament, in 2012, and now to be given the highest civilian honour by the Government of India meant a lot to me. As a Member of Parliament, my plan is to work towards making sports that much more viable in India (Sport for All) and also to integrate sports within the educational framework in the country.

The honour was formally conferred on me at the Rashtrapati Bhavan in Delhi on 4 February 2014 in an extraordinary ceremony at the Ashok Hall. As we entered the hall, a military band started playing and when my name was called, it was one of the most unbelievable moments of my life. To receive the Bharat Ratna in front of my wife and daughter (Arjun could not make it because he had a game in Mumbai), and to be told by the President that the whole country was proud of me, gave me an incredible sense of fulfilment. It was a day when I felt well and truly overwhelmed.

When I started out as a sixteen-year-old against Pakistan in 1989, I could never have imagined how it would all end. I always tried to work as hard as I could and give my best for the team. While I may have failed on occasions, I never gave up. It was my country I was playing for and that was all I had wanted to do when I had started to play under the strict vigil of Achrekar Sir in Shivaji Park.

In all those years, I never compromised on hard work and discipline and always tried to push the bar higher. To achieve something worthwhile for India was a dream I chased all my life.

Full circle

In my farewell speech at the Wankhede Stadium, I mentioned that during my career Achrekar Sir had never said ‘well done’, but the truth is that